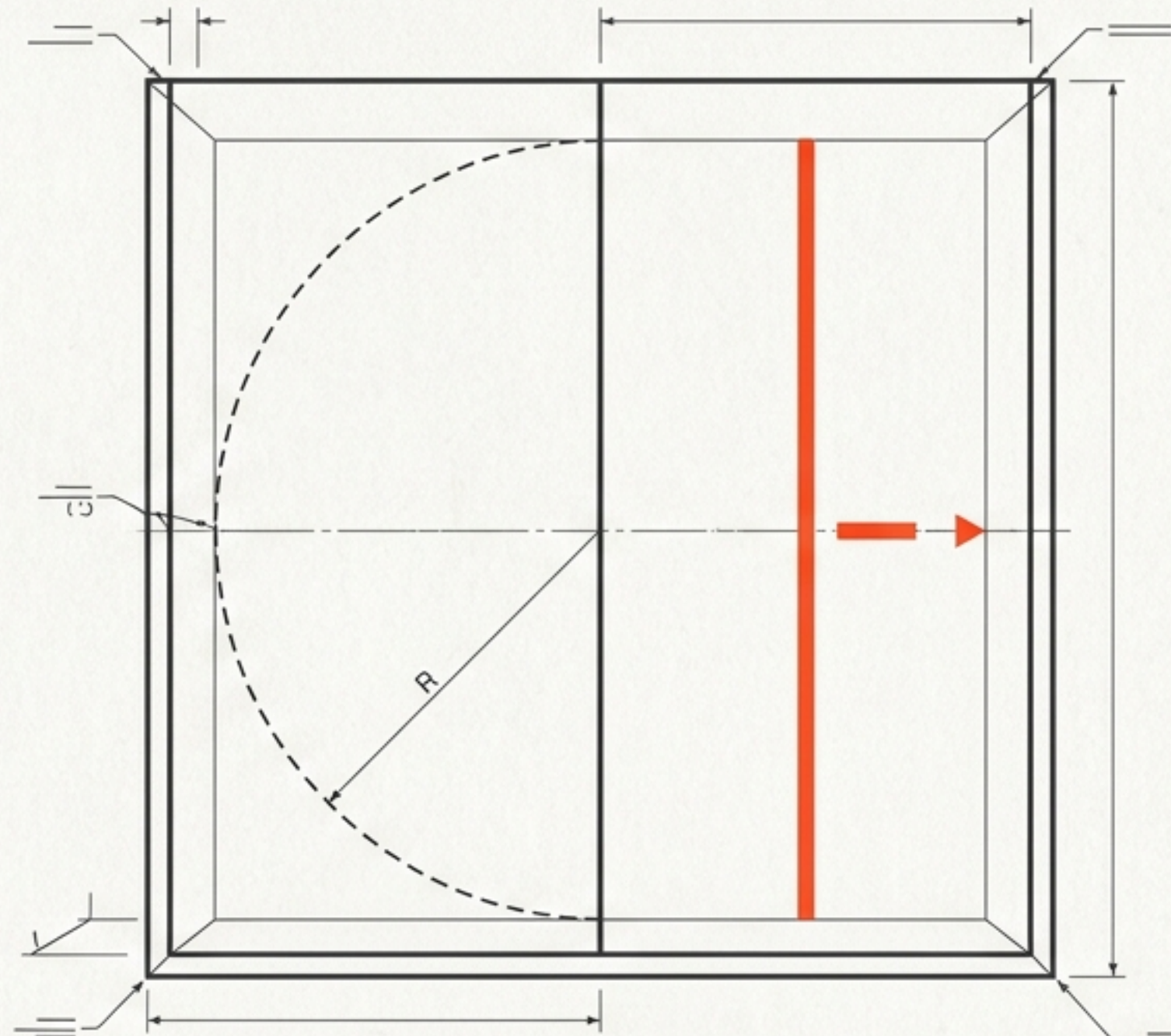




The Architecture of Korean Vowels

A phonetic geometry framework for reading Hangeul.



+



[Vowel Box]

=

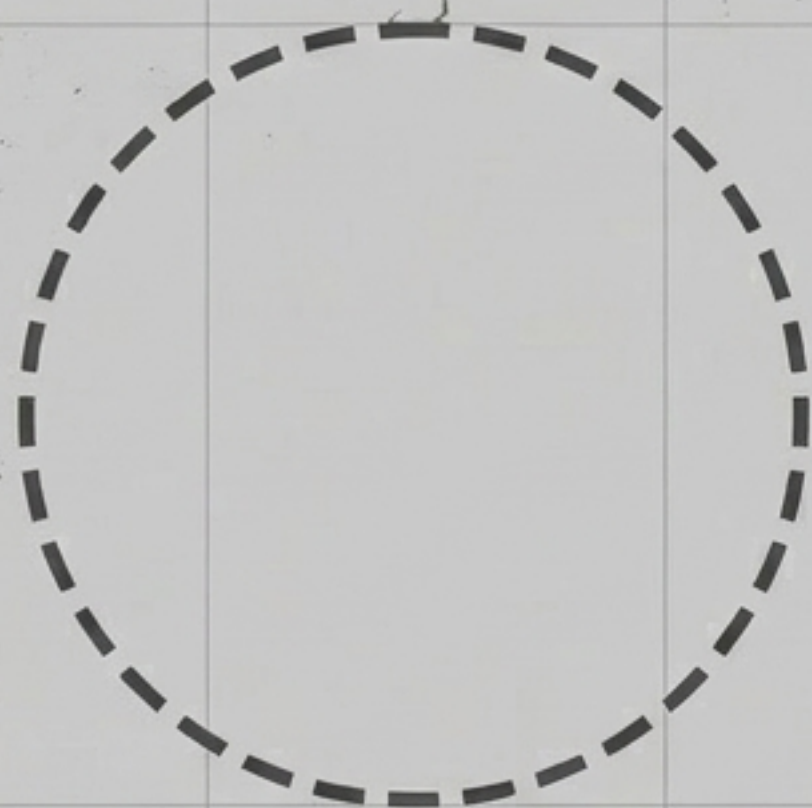
[Invalid]

Vowels require structural support

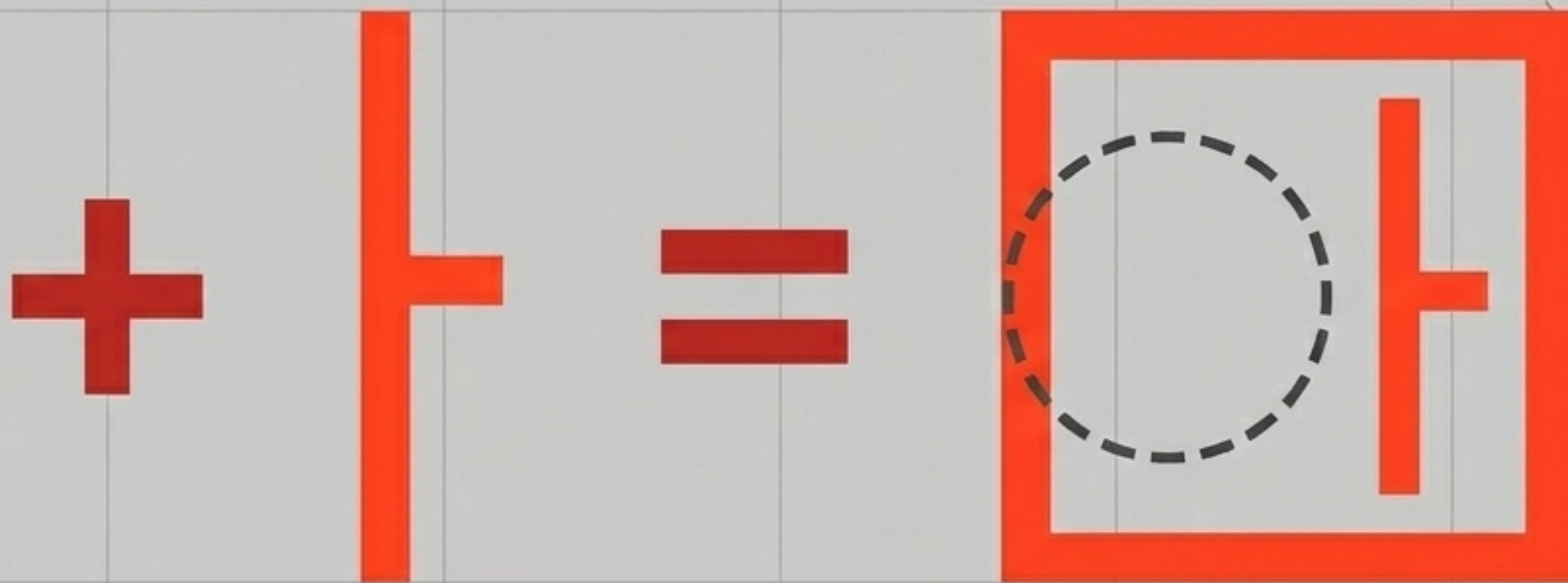
In the geometric system of Hangul, a **vowel cannot** form a character on its own. Every syllable block demands a starting consonant to act as a structural anchor, even if the syllable only makes a vowel sound.

The zero-value placeholder

Meet 'o' (**ieung**). When placed at the beginning of a word, it wears an **invisible cloak**. It makes absolutely no sound, but it provides the necessary structural scaffolding for the vowel to stand upright.

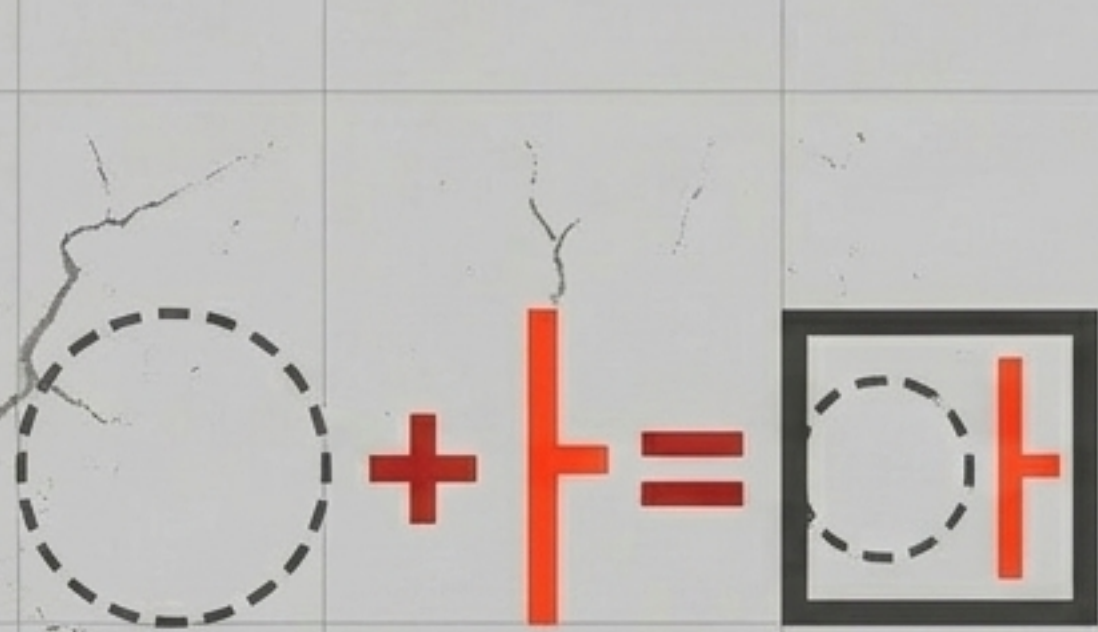


The Invisible Cloak

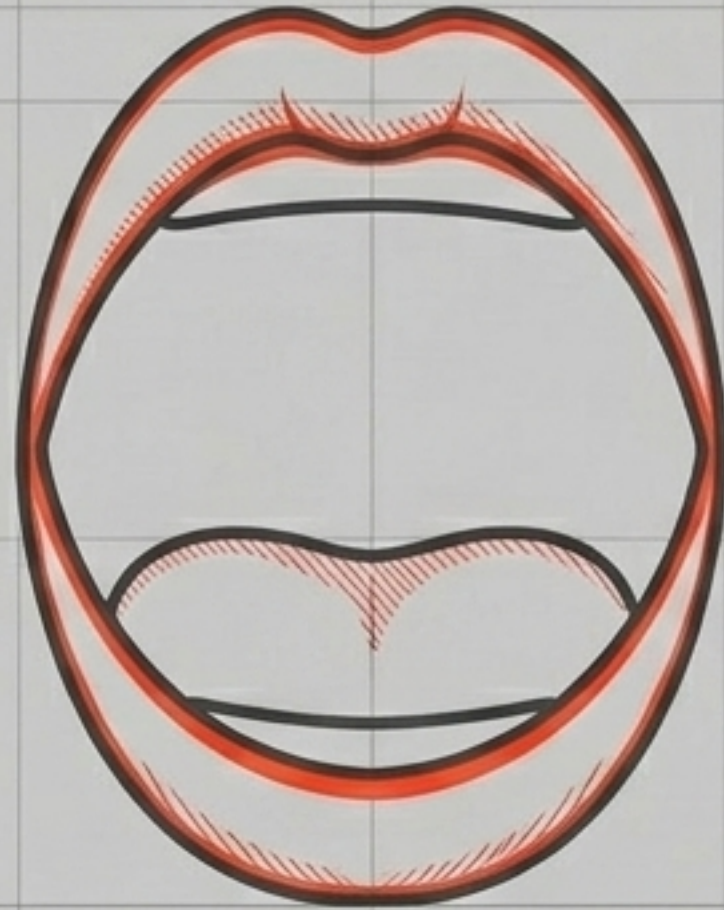


ㅏ (a) requires a wide, open jaw

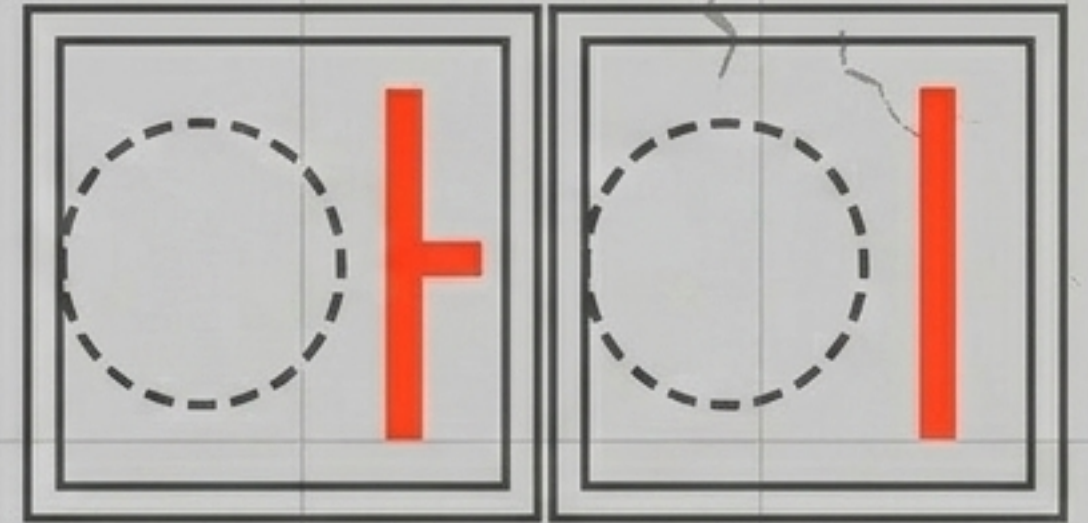
Open your mouth wide and say 'Ah!'—like a child calling for their mom.



[Syllable Block]



[Mouth Shape]

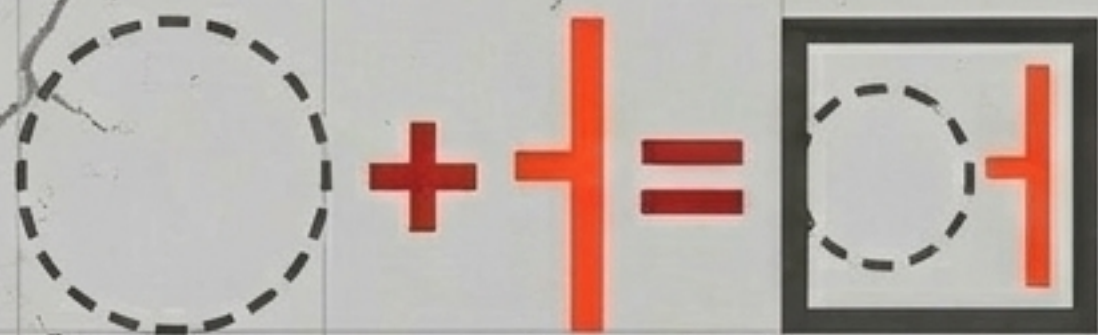


Vocabulary:

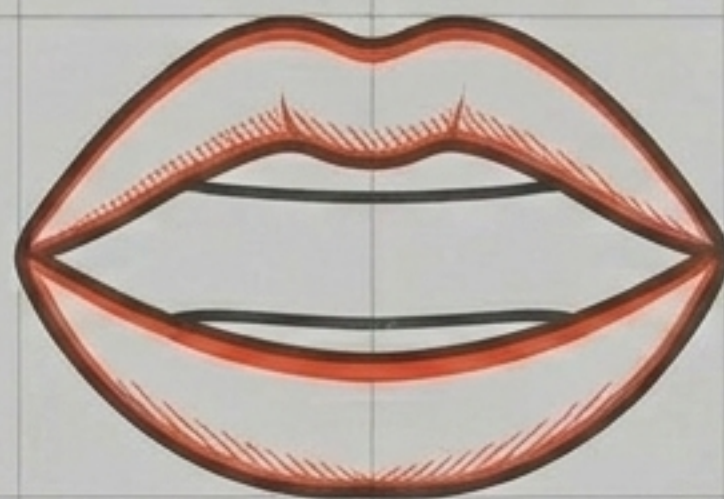
아이 (Child). Notice how both syllable blocks in this word rely on the 'o' placeholder.

어 (eo) resonates from the back of the throat

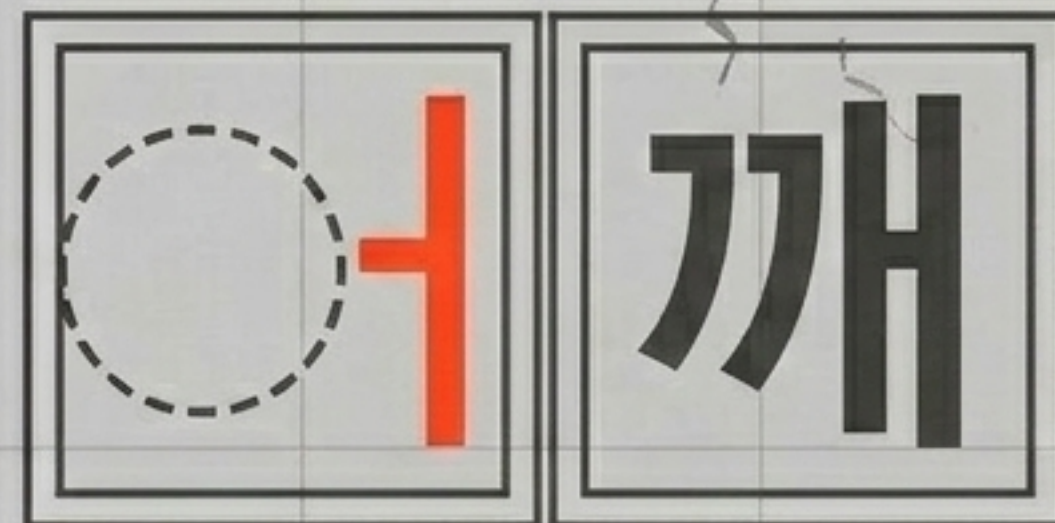
Open your mouth slightly less than '0ㅏ' and generate the sound from deep in the throat.



[Syllable Block]



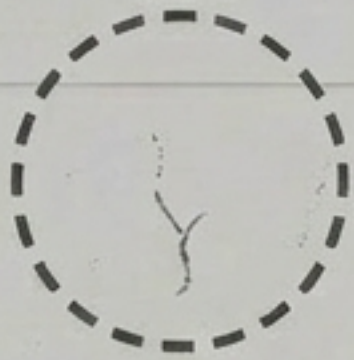
[Mouth Shape & Sound Origin]



Vocabulary:
어깨 (Shoulder).

오 (o) relies on perfectly rounded lips

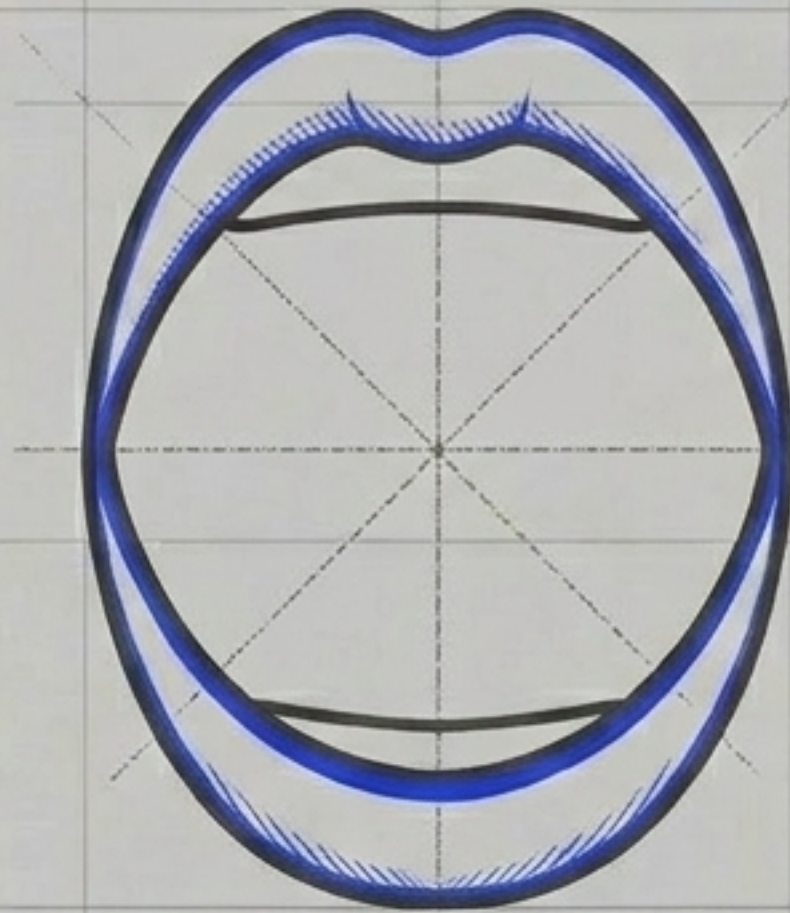
Simply round your lips into a circle and make an 'Oh~' sound.



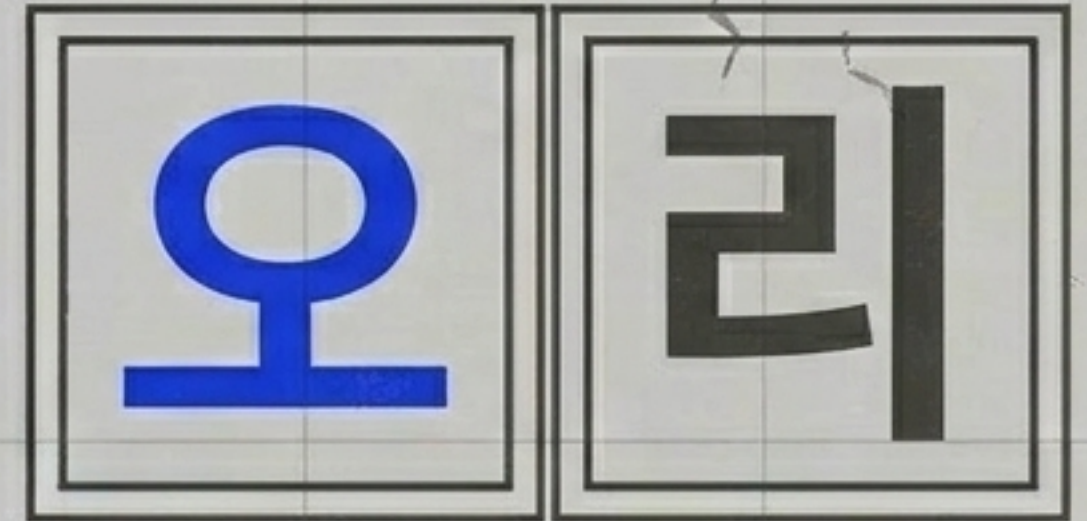
=



[Syllable Block]



[Mouth Shape]

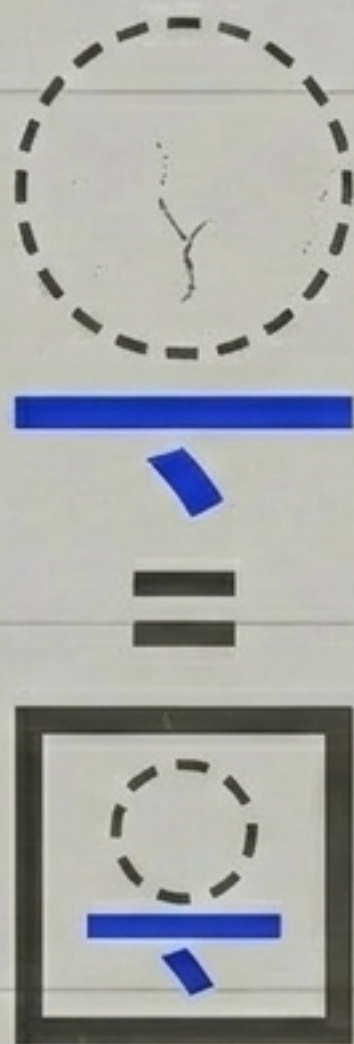


Vocabulary:

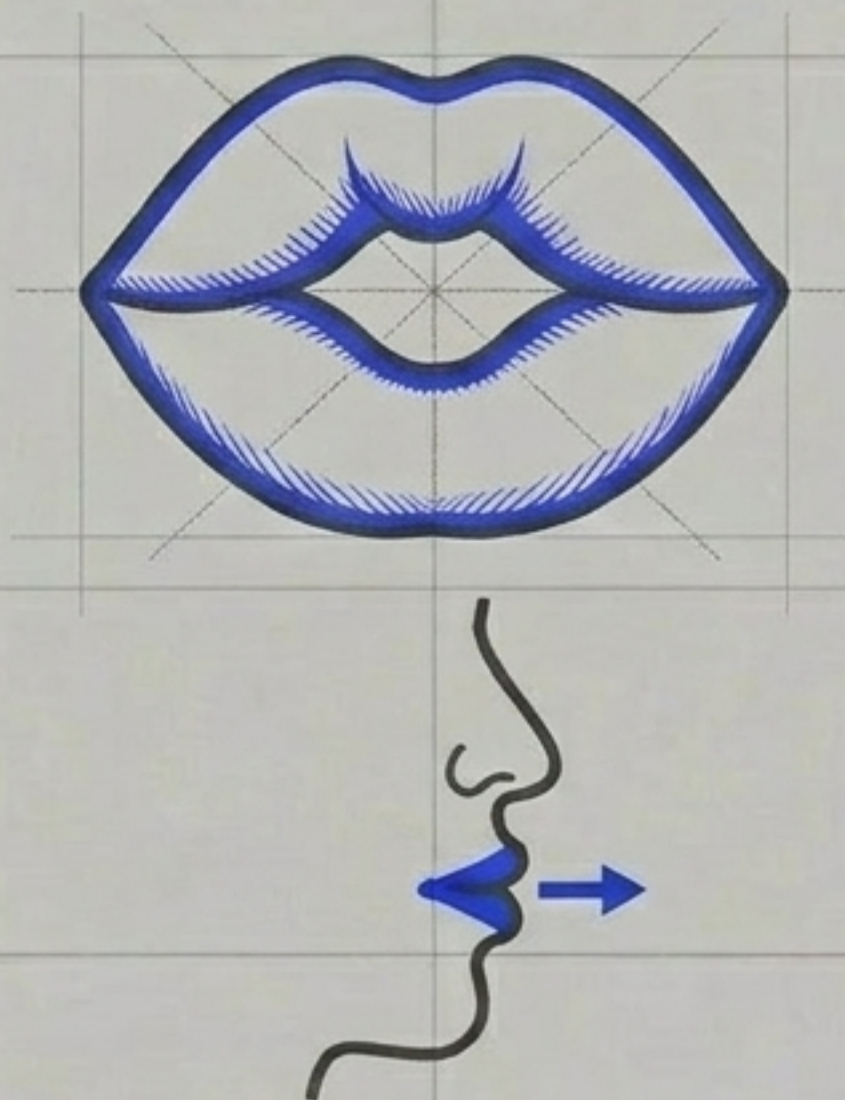
오리 (Duck).

우 (u) demands extreme lip protrusion

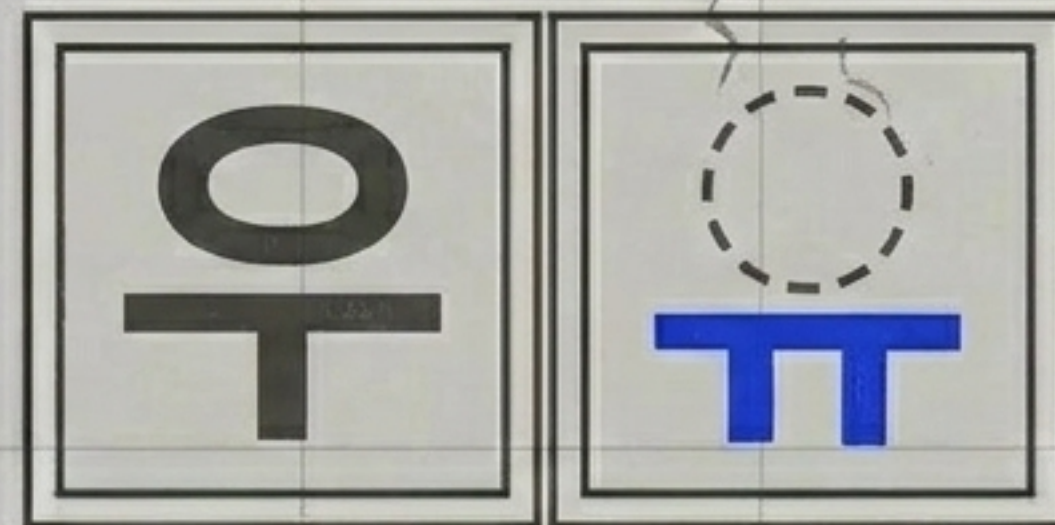
Push your lips forward and pronounce a tight 'Woo~'.



[Syllable Block]



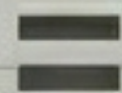
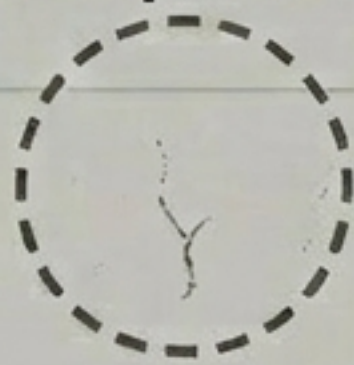
[Mouth Shape]



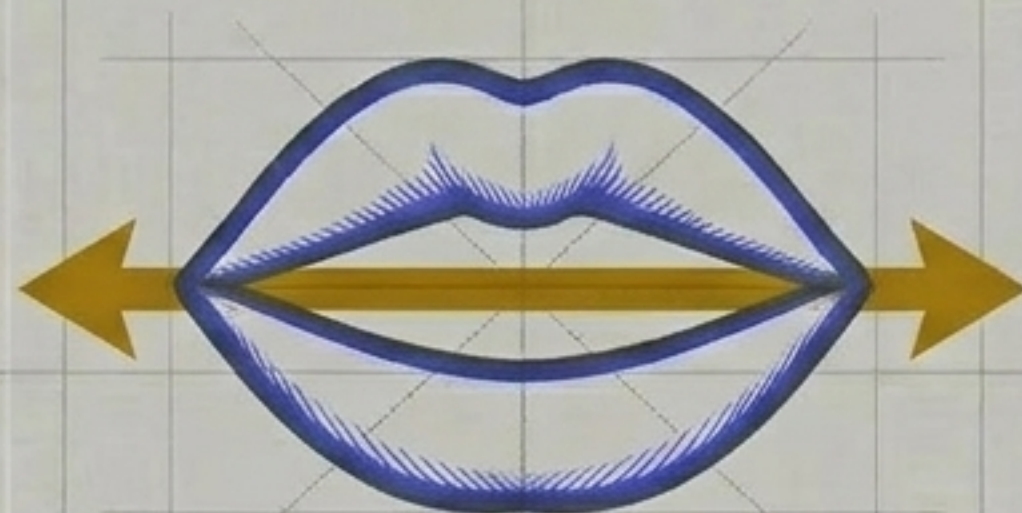
Vocabulary: 우유 (Milk).
Both syllables stack a
consonant placeholder over
a horizontal vowel base.

으 (eu) pulls the mouth into a relaxed, flat line

A uniquely challenging sound for learners. Relax your mouth completely, open your lips sideways, and make a flat 'Eu~' sound.



[Syllable Block]



[Mouth Shape]

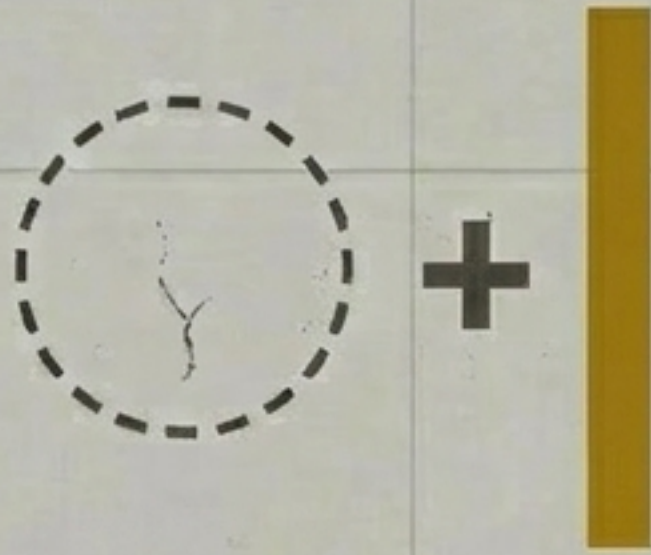


Vocabulary:

은행 (Bank).

0| (i) stretches the lips tightly to the sides

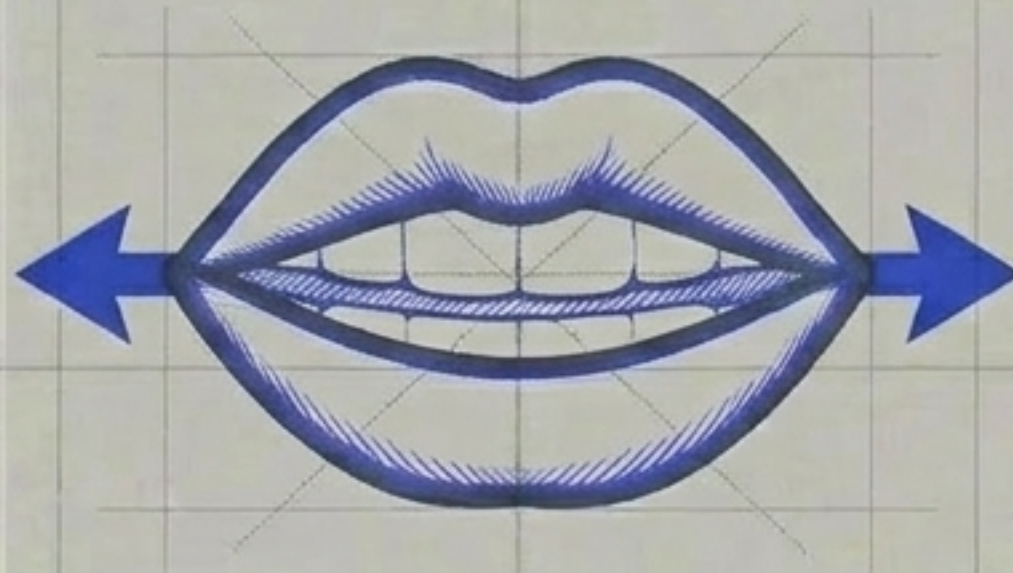
Pull your lips slightly outward to the sides and say a sharp 'Ee~'.



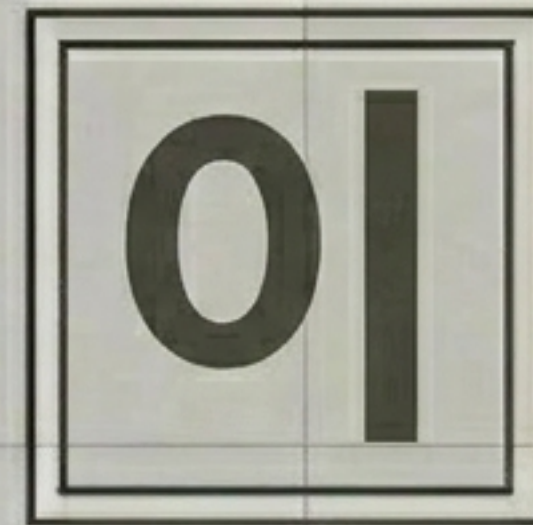
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[Syllable Block]



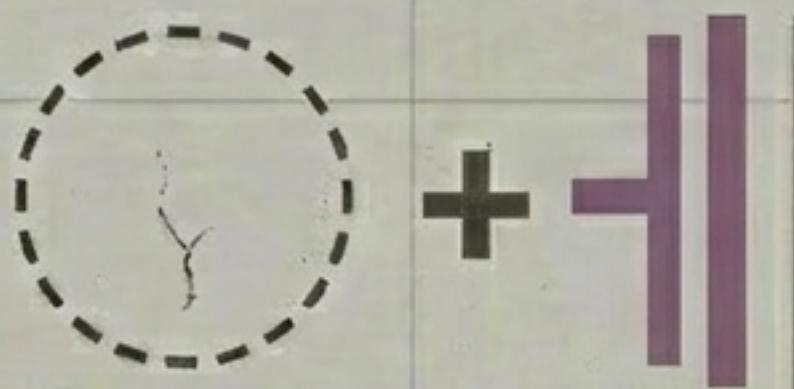
[Mouth Shape]



Vocabulary: 0| (Tooth / The number Two). A perfect example of a single architected block functioning as a complete concept.

OH (ae) requires a wider drop

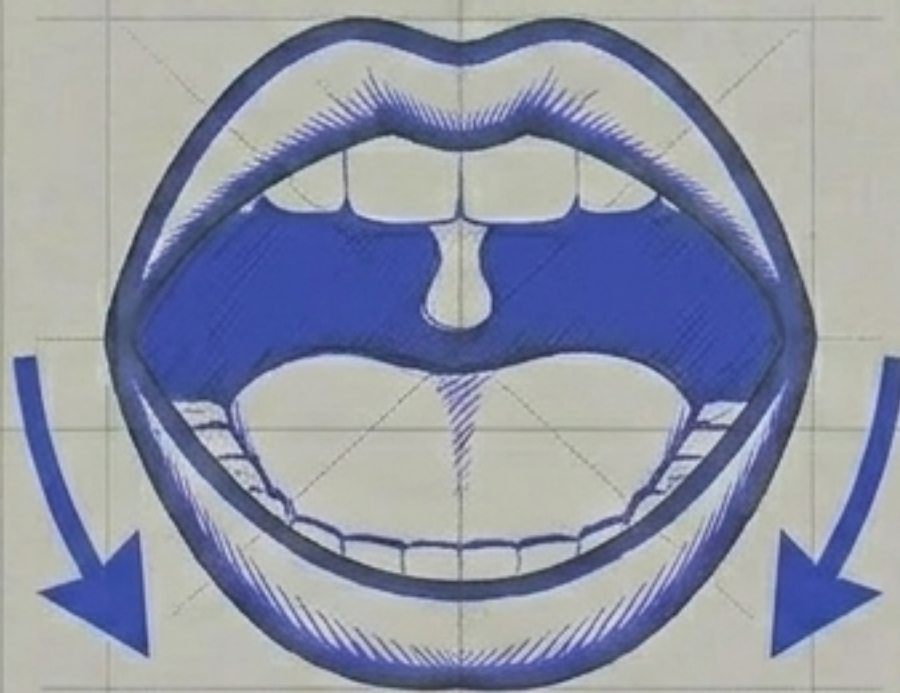
Drop your jaw wider and say 'Ae~'.



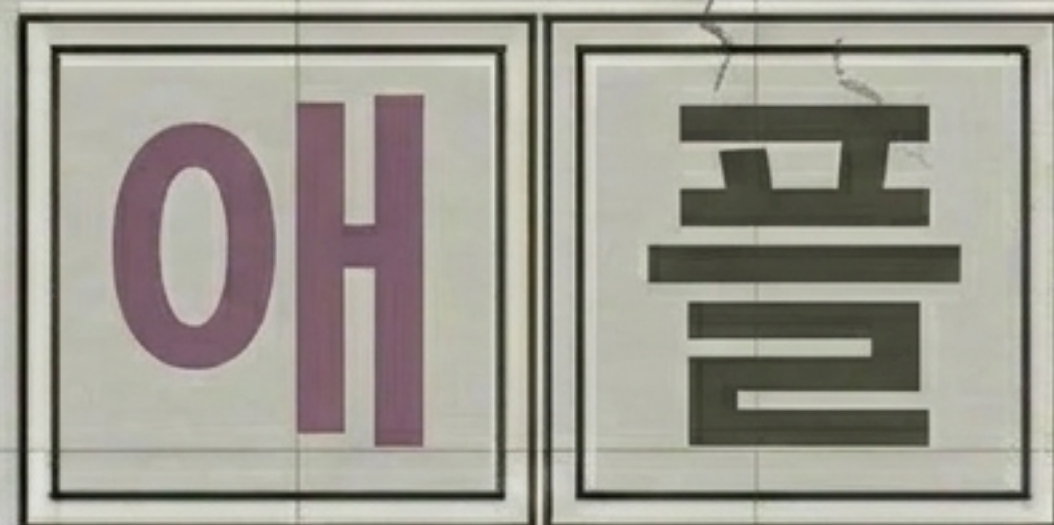
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[Syllable Block]



[Mouth Shape]

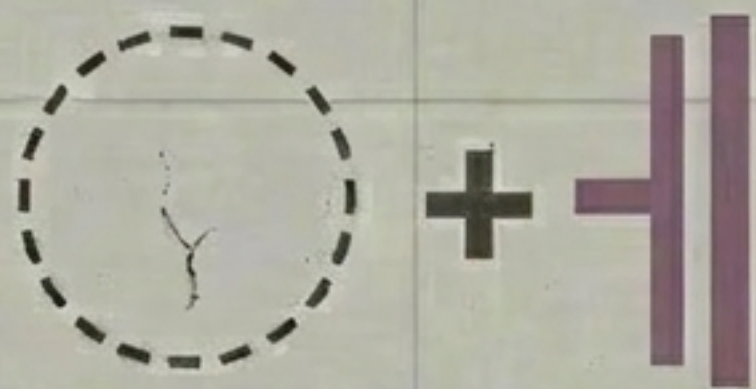


Vocabulary:

애플 (Apple - English loanword).

어 (e) uses a narrower, relaxed opening

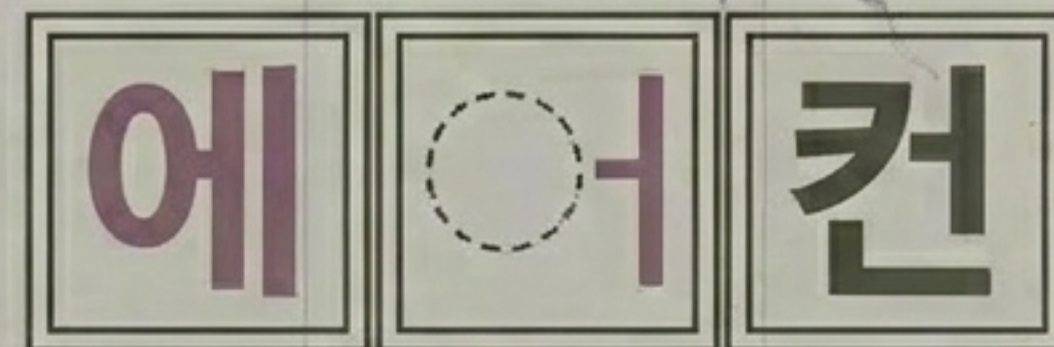
Very similar to '애', but open your mouth less and comfortably make an 'E~' sound.



[Syllable Block]



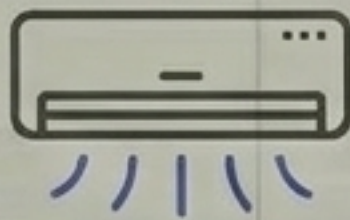
[Mouth Shape]



Vocabulary: 에어컨 (Air Conditioner). Notice the sequential use of placeholder blocks: 에 and 어.

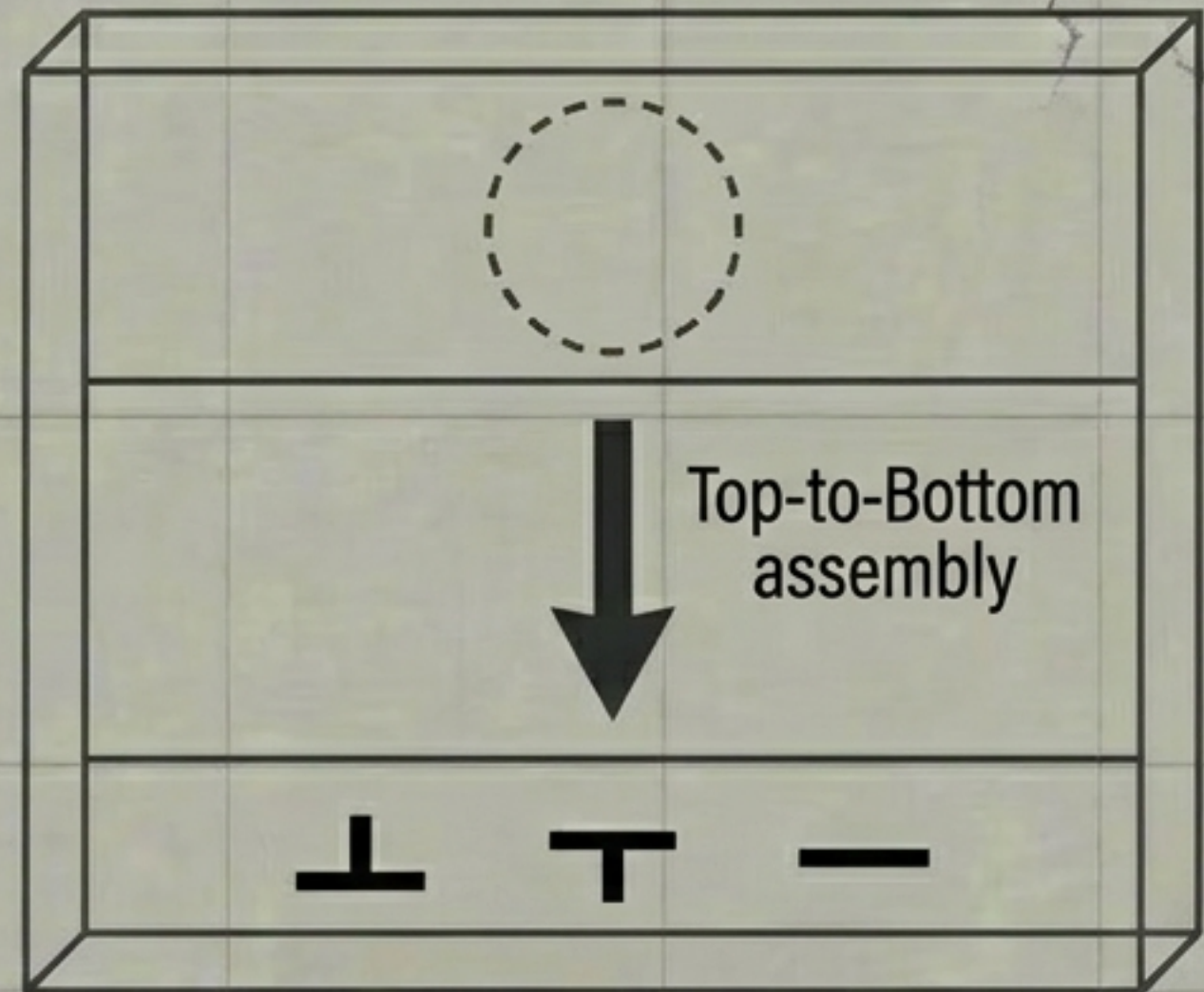
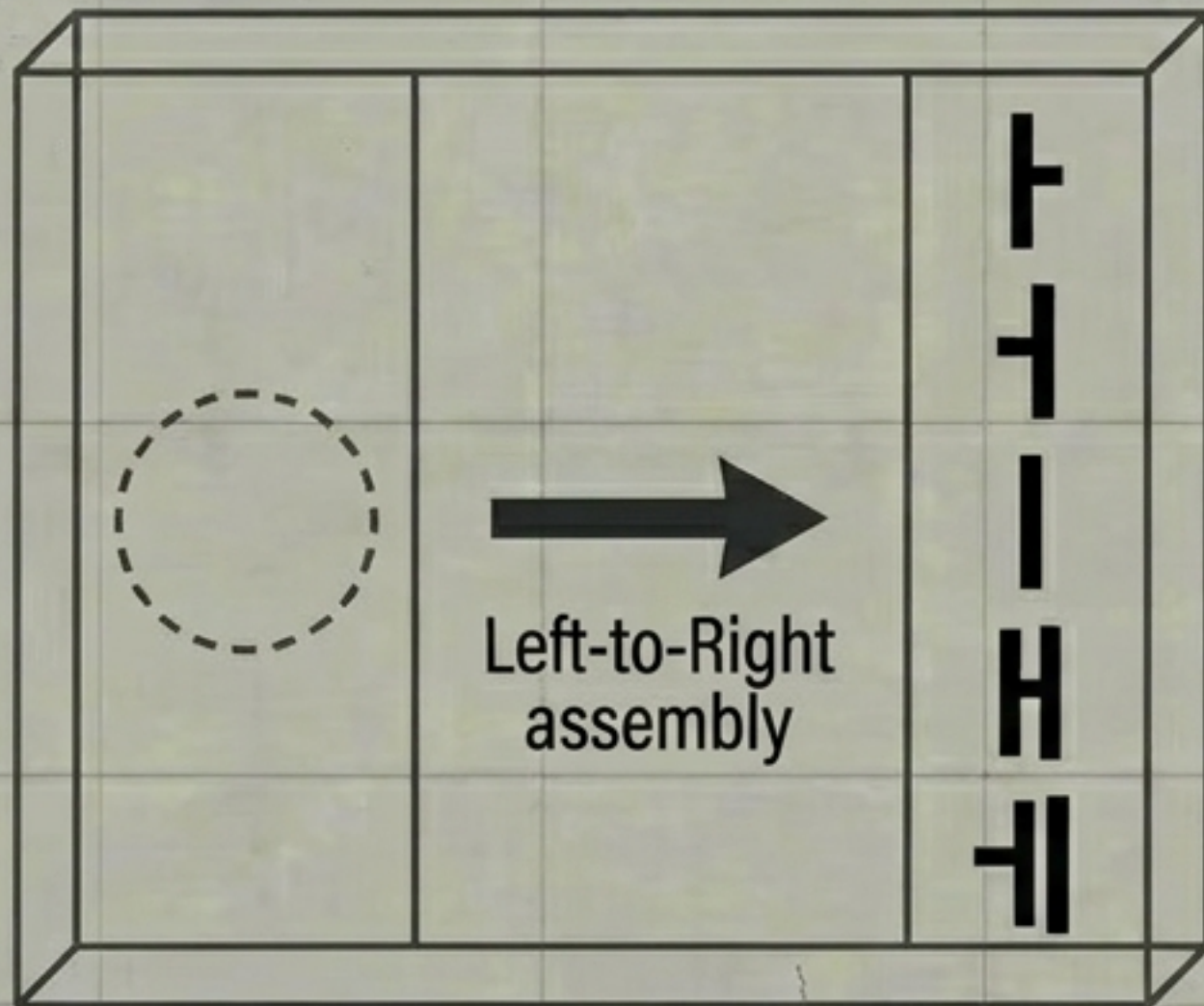
Diagnostic Matrix: Differentiating the near-twins

The structural difference between **ㅏ** and **ㅑ** directly maps to the physical distance between your upper and lower teeth.

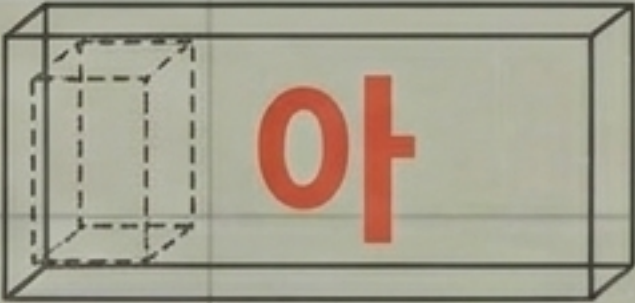
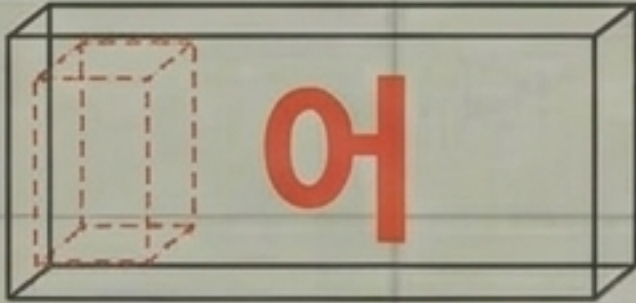
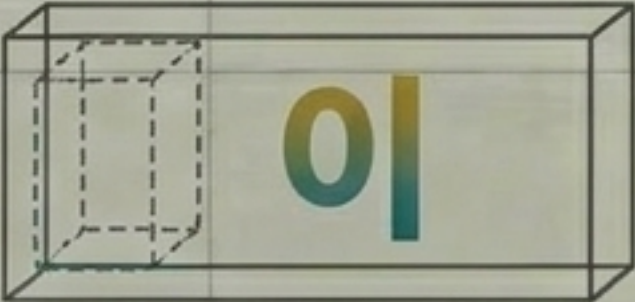
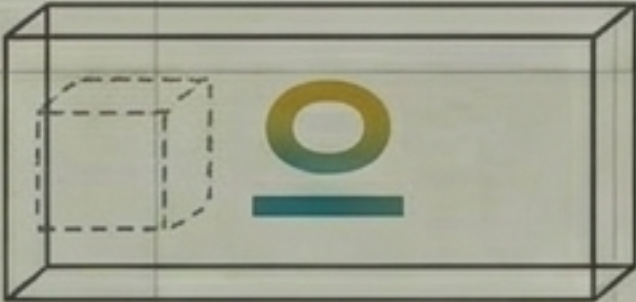
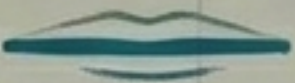
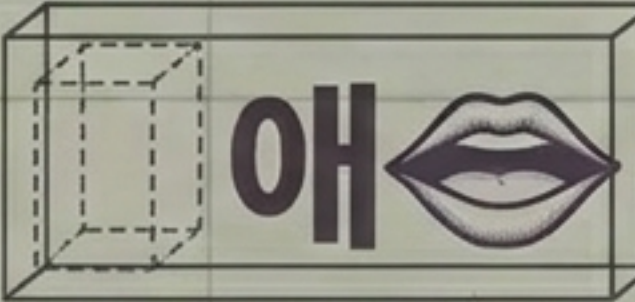
ㅏ (ae)	ㅑ (e)
ㅏ	ㅑ
	
	
애플	에어컨

Form follows pronunciation

Hangul is not a random collection of shapes. The geometric orientation of the vowel—whether it is a tall vertical line or a flat horizontal line—dictates the entire architecture of the syllable block. Tall vowels stand beside the placeholder; flat vowels sit beneath it.



The Vowel Architecture Matrix

	Vertical Blocks (Left/Right)		Horizontal Blocks (Top/Bottom)	
Open Jaw	 아	 어		
Rounded Lips			 오	 우
Flat Stretch	 이		 우	
Complex Flare	 애	 에		

The silent 'ㅇ' combined with geometric vowels creates a perfect phonetic map. Consistent practice with this blueprint will structurally permanently improve your Korean reading speed.